Sales Training Debrief — Session 17

Close the Exits. Hold the Line. Win the Deal.

Sales training led by Corie Dawson, Director · Thursday 28 May 2026 · Marketing Sweet

1. Reading the buying signals — the laugh is interest

The session opened with a debrief of a pitch where the rep took the price up, the buyer laughed and shook her head, and the rep instantly dropped two tiers. The first lesson: when a buyer reacts strongly to a price — laughs, scoffs, pushes back — that is a buying signal, not a rejection. People who aren't interested don't bother engaging with the price. They politely end the call.

> *"You either have the money or you don't. That's the first thing to understand. Don't worry about what people say, worry about what they do."*

What the laugh actually means:

- They're engaged enough in the conversation to react.
- They're testing whether you'll fold under pressure.
- They're looking for permission to keep negotiating, not to walk away.
- They're measuring whether you actually believe in the price you just quoted.

The correct response is not to drop the price. It's to test the legitimacy of the objection with a calm, controlled question — and to confirm alignment on everything else before touching the number.

2. Don't take pot shots — every drop costs credibility

The pattern that needs to stop: rep pitches gold, gets pushback, drops to silver, gets pushback, drops to bronze, gets pushback. Each drop in the same conversation isn't flexibility — it's a credibility leak. By the third price, the buyer has stopped listening to the offer and started enjoying the dance.

> *"Every time you take a pot shot, you're losing credibility — at an exponential rate."*

The mechanics of why pot-shotting fails:

1. First drop: the buyer thinks they've found leverage and pushes again.
2. Second drop: the buyer concludes the original price was inflated and stops trusting any number you say.
3. Third drop: the buyer knows you can be moved indefinitely. The deal is now about how low you'll go, not what you're selling.

The fix is to pause, confirm alignment, and force the buyer to commit to a target — not to keep firing different prices at them.

3. Confirm alignment first — close the doors before talking price

Before any price discussion, the rep needs to confirm two things explicitly: does the buyer like the process, and does the buyer like the company. Both must be answered before the conversation returns to money. This is the foundation move that almost every miss in the session was missing.

The sequence:

4. Acknowledge the price reaction without flinching. "I understand $7,700 is a lot of money."
5. Pivot to the work itself. "You need to do something about this website — whether with us or with someone else. Can we agree on that?" Wait for yes.
6. Confirm the process. "What do you think of the process? Does that work for your business?" Wait for yes.
7. Only now ask about expectation. "Can you help me out here — what were you expecting to pay, roughly?"

> *"It just sounds to me that this is the easiest part — the price — which is where most people struggle. The price is actually the easiest part of my job, once we agree on everything else."*

4. The alligator farm — every objection is an exit point

The central metaphor of the session. A pitch is a babysitter watching a small, restless child inside a house surrounded by an alligator farm — no fences, no safety net. The child wants to escape. The babysitter's only job is to close every exit before the child finds one. Every objection a buyer raises is a window or a door the child is testing.

What the exits actually are:

- "I don't like the process" — the side door.
- "I'm not sure about your company" — the back door.
- "The price is wrong" — the front window.
- "I need to think about it" — the bedroom window.
- "I want to do it another way" — the alligator-side exit.

The job is to predict the pattern of which exit the buyer will try next, get there first, and close it calmly — not to chase the buyer to whichever exit they're running for in the moment. That chase is what kills deals.

> *"You won't stop the child from getting out the window by chilling out. Close it before they get there. Yeah, we can do that for you — or no, we can't. Don't be silly. Hit them with that energy. Close it off."*

5. The dog and the car — chase is the opposite of close

A second metaphor for the same principle, presented for the reps who didn't connect with the alligator farm. A dog running away on the beach won't come back if you chase it — the chase becomes the game. The way to bring the dog back is to walk in the opposite direction. The dog ends up chasing you.

The pattern translates directly to a pitch:

CHASE (LOSES THE DEAL)	WALK AWAY (WINS THE DEAL)
Buyer says no — rep counters with a lower price.	Buyer says no — rep confirms alignment, then walks back the offer.
Rep talks more, faster, when the buyer pulls back.	Rep slows down. Becomes a little disinterested.
Rep apologises for the price.	Rep stands behind the price and recommends the product anyway.
Buyer feels the desperation and uses it for leverage.	Buyer feels the indifference and starts pulling toward the deal.
The energy is salesperson-on-commission.	The energy is professional-with-options.

> *"This whole thing is a game. Push and pull. Tug of war. You have to know when to let the rope go to create imbalance. There's no point fighting it — use their own body weight against them."*

6. Acknowledge the buyer’s number literally — let them break character

Once the buyer states a target — say, three to four thousand on a job that genuinely costs six to seven — the move is not to negotiate toward their number. The move is to acknowledge the number literally and tell them, calmly, that you can’t get there. This forces the buyer to either confirm the number (in which case they walk away, revealing they were never serious) or break character (in which case the real price tolerance becomes visible).

Why this works psychologically:

- Buyers who throw out a target are usually testing — they don’t expect you to take it seriously.
- When you treat the number as the firm constraint they claim it is, they suddenly have to decide whether to back it up.
- Most buyers who quoted a low number to test you will quietly stretch when the rep doesn’t fold. Their stated number was never the real one.
- Buyers who genuinely can’t pay more reveal themselves cleanly. You stop wasting time on them — which is its own win.

> *"I'm taking you seriously. You said three to four thousand. That's the price. I can't get there. So here's what I'd recommend instead."*

7. The discount path that doesn't break the line

After acknowledging you can't get to the buyer's number, the next move is to offer a path back toward it that doesn't involve dropping the price of the work. The session's specific example: the hosting discount. The website price stays the same. The discount sits on a separate line that activates only if the buyer takes a related action (in this case, hosting with the agency).

The structure:

8. Hold the value: "The work is what the work costs. I can't shrink it."
9. Offer the path: "If you bring your hosting to us, there's a 25% discount on the project."
10. Recalculate audibly: "That brings it down from $6,300 to $4,700."
11. Acknowledge it's still not their number: "That's not where you wanted to be, but it's the closest I can get without compromising the work."
12. Send the proposal — don't close on the spot.

Why this lands:

- The buyer gets a meaningful concession without the rep dropping price.
- The agency keeps the buyer on hosting for the long term — a bigger lifetime number.
- The buyer feels they earned the move, not extracted it.

8. The $700 lesson — buyers pay extra to feel like they won

The most counterintuitive principle of the session. A buyer says $22,000 is their target on a $28,000 car. The salesperson disappears, performs the routine — phone calls, paperwork, looking sweaty, looking rattled — and comes back with $22,700. Not $22,000. Seven hundred dollars over the buyer's stated maximum. The buyer takes it almost every time.

> *"You're paying $700 to feel like you've won. Why? Because in your eyes, you broke me. You said you couldn't go higher than $22,000 — and I couldn't get anywhere near it. But we all know it's right next to it. That's the magic."*

The mechanism:

13. The buyer's stated number is a position, not a true ceiling. Their actual maximum is whatever they'll pay if they feel they won the negotiation.
14. Visible effort on the seller's side signals authentic struggle. The buyer interprets it as evidence they pushed hard enough.
15. Coming in slightly above the buyer's number — but visibly far from the original — produces the maximum sense of victory.
16. If the seller simply agreed to $22,000 with no struggle, the buyer would feel suspicious — the easy yes means the seller had more room to give.

THE WARNING Never close the small gap by asking the buyer to come up the last $700. That breaks the spell. The buyer must come up on their own, because they've decided they won.

9. Disinterest as positioning power

A specific tonal move that comes up later in the session. When a buyer is treating the rep poorly — laughing, pushing, being rude — the antidote is calibrated disinterest. Not rudeness, not retaliation. A slight, professional pulling-back that signals the rep has other places to be and isn't emotionally invested in this single deal.

> *"It doesn't really affect me whether you go with us or not. This is your business you're talking about, and this website without being rude is dreadful. I have a job. I get paid a wage. The commission isn't going to change my life. So you've got to make a decision."*

Why this works:

- It removes the buyer's leverage. They can't threaten to walk away from a deal the rep isn't fighting for.
- It triggers the same scarcity instinct as anti-pursuit in any relationship. The buyer suddenly wants what isn't being pushed on them.
- It protects the rep's mindset for the next call. The rep walks out of a rude conversation with the same energy they walked in with.

The line that holds this in balance: be disinterested without being dismissive. The rep still recommends the product, still sends the proposal, still treats the buyer with respect — but does not chase.

10. "I understand" — the universal disarm

A single phrase that, used well, defuses almost any objection or hostility a buyer brings. "I understand" is acknowledgement without agreement. It says: I heard you, I take your position seriously, I'm not going to fight you on it. Then the conversation moves forward.

> *"There's a reason it works in marriage and it works in sales. 'I understand' is one of the greatest tools in the kit. Put it in your toolkit and use it deliberately."*

How to deploy it:

- Buyer raises an objection that has no good answer → "I understand." Pause. Continue.
- Buyer is hostile or rude → "I understand." Don't engage with the hostility.
- Buyer pushes on price you can't move → "I understand. We may not be the right fit at that number."
- Buyer asks for something you can't deliver → "I understand. Here's what I can do instead."

The phrase has to be calm and genuine. Said dismissively, it sounds patronising. Said with real attention, it's the most disarming sentence in sales.

11. Honesty, integrity, loyalty — the three pillars

The closing principle of the session. Underneath every technique covered — buying signals, holding the line, acknowledging the number, the $700 move, the disinterest tone, "I understand" — sits a foundation of three values. Reps who run the techniques without the values come across as manipulative. Reps who run the techniques on top of the values come across as professional and trustworthy.

PILLAR	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN A PITCH
HONESTY	Tell the buyer the truth about whether you're the right fit. Don't take a deal you know will go badly.
INTEGRITY	Stand behind your value. Don't fold the price beyond what the work is worth, even to win the deal.
LOYALTY	Recommend the right product for the buyer, not the most profitable one. Loyalty to the buyer compounds into loyalty back to the agency.

> *"Honesty, integrity, loyalty. People aren't interested in what you say — they're interested in what you do. Show the three pillars every place, everywhere, every time."*

12. Action items this week

17. When a buyer laughs at your price, hold. Don't drop. Test the legitimacy of the objection with a question instead.
18. Before any price discussion, confirm alignment on process and company. Get two yeses before talking money.
19. Stop taking pot shots. If the first price is rejected, don't fire a second one — confirm alignment first.
20. When the buyer states a low target, acknowledge it literally. Say you can't get there. Let them break character.
21. Offer the hosting-discount move (or equivalent) as the path back — not a discount on the work itself.
22. If a buyer becomes rude, shift to calibrated disinterest. Stay professional, lose the chase energy.
23. Use "I understand" deliberately three times this week. Notice how it changes the rest of the conversation.
24. Audit your last five pitches: were you the chasing dog, or were you the car driving away?

THE ONE-LINER Close the exits before you talk price. Hold the line when they laugh. Let them come to you — and let them feel like they won.